Multi-Cultural Collection

By Regie Cabico, Margaret Burroughs and Willie Perdomo

Check One by Regie Cabico

The Government asks me to "check one" if I
want money.
I just laugh in their face and say,
"How can you ask me to be one race?"

INTRODUCTION

Who can say what race a person belongs to strictly by his or her appearance? Labeling leads people to distinguish themselves from others based on a racial category. Why must we label people at all? Each person is different and possesses unique qualities. Check one race? How about The Human Race. This is a Collection on the concept of Race.

I stand proudly before you a fierce Filipino
who knows how to belt hard-gospel songs
played to African drums at a Catholic mass-

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and loving the music to suffering beats,
and lashes from men's eyes on the capitol
streets-

South-East D.C..., with its sleepy crime,
my mother nursed patients from seven to
nine,
patients gray from the railroad
riding past civil rights

I walked their tracks when I entertained
them at the chapel and made their canes
pillars
of percussion to my heavy gospel-
my comedy out-loud, laughing about, our
shared,
stolen experiences of the South.

Would it surprise you if I told you my blood
was delivered from North off Portuguese
vessels

who gave me spiritual stones and the turn in
my eyes-
my father's name when they conquered the
Pacific Isles.
My hair is black and thick as "negrito,"
growing abundant
as "sampaguita"-flowers defying civilization
like pilipino pygmies that dance in the
mountain.

I could give you an epic about my ways of life
or my look
and you want me to fill it in "one square box."
From what integer or shape do you count
existing identities,
grant loans for the mind, or crayola white
census sheets-
There's no "one kind" to fill for anyone.

You tell me who I am, what gets the most
money

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and I'll sing that song like a one-man
caravan.
I know arias from Naples, Tunis, and Accra-
lullabyes from welfare, food-stamps, and
nature

and you want me to sing one song?
I have danced jigs with Jim Crow and
shuffled my hips
to a sonic guitar of Clapton and Hendrix,
waltzed with dead lovers, skipped to bamboo
sticks,
belleted kabuki and mimed cathacali
arrivedercied-a-rhumba and tapped Tin Pan
Alley-
and you want me to dance the Bhagavad Gita
on a box to small for a thumbelina-thin diva?

I'll check "other"

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Regie Cabico
Book: Returning a Borrowed Tongue
ISBN: 978-1566890434
Publisher: Coffee House
Date (Month/Year): 1995

TRANSITION

In 1970, 1 in 100 babies born was multiracial; these days, that number has climbed to 1 in 10. By 2050, 1 in 5 Americans is expected to be multiracial. Why is this important? Because in America, multiracial individuals are always labeled as "non-white" – and in America today, it's still a white man's world. What Shall I Tell My Children who are Black by Margaret Burroughs.

What Shall I Tell My Children Who Are Black by Margaret Burroughs

What shall I tell my children who are black
Of what it means to be a captive in this dark skin?
What shall I tell my dear one, fruit of my womb,
of how beautiful they are when everywhere they turn

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they are faced with abhorrence of everything that is black.
The night is black and so is the boogyman.
Villains are black with black hearts.
A black cow gives no milk. A black hen lays no eggs.
Storm clouds, black, black is evil
and evil is black and devil's food is black…

What shall I tell my dear ones raised in a white world
A place where white has been made to represent
all that is good and pure and fine and decent,
where clouds are white and dolls, and heaven
surely is a white, white place with angels
robed in white, and cotton candy and ice cream
and milk and ruffled Sunday dresses
and dream houses and long sleek Cadillacs and Angel's food is white… all, all… white.

What can I say therefore, when my child
Comes home in tears because a playmate
Has called him black, big lipped, flatnosed and nappy headed?

What will he think when I dry his tears and whisper,
"Yes, that's true. But no less beautiful and dear."
How shall I lift up his head, get him to square
his shoulders, look his adversaries in the eye,
confident in the knowledge of his worth.
Serene under his sable skin and proud of his own
beauty?

What can I do to give him strength
That he may come through life's adversities
As a whole human being unwarped and human in a world
Of biased laws and inhuman practices, that he might
Survive. And survive he must! For who knows?
Perhaps this black child here bears the genius
To discover the cure for… cancer
Or to chart the course for exploration of the universe.
So, he must survive for the the good of all humanity.

He must and will survive.
I have drunk deeply of late from the fountain
of my black culture, sat at the knee of and learned
from mother Africa, discovered the truth of my

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heritage.
The truth, so often obscured and omitted.
And I find I have much to say to my black children.
I will lift up their heads in proud blackness
with the story of their fathers and their father's
fathers.
And I shall take them into a way back time
of kings and queens who ruled the Nile,
and measured the stars and discovered the laws of
mathematics.
I will tell them of a black people upon whose backs have
been built
the wealth of three continents.
I will tell him this and more.
And knowledge of his heritage shall be his weapon and
his armor;
It will make him strong enough to win any battle he may
face.
And since this story is so often obscured,
I must sacrifice to find it for my children,
even as I sacrifice to feed, clothe and shelter them.

So this I will do for them if I love them.

None will do it for me.

I must find the truth of heritage for myself and pass it on to them.

In years to come, I believe because I have armed them with the truth,

my children and their children's children will venerate me.

For it is the truth that will make us free!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Margaret Burroughs
Book: Writing African American Women
ISBN: 978-0313331961
Publisher: Greenwood
Date (Month/Year): April 2006

SOURCE INFORMATION

2003 National Qualifier

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TRANSITION

In a climate currently riddled with anti-immigrant and anti-Latino rhetoric, people of mixed-race (black and Latino) face significant challenges as well. Afro-Latinos are often deemed too black for the Latino culture and not black enough for African Americans. Willie Perdomo explains in Nigger-Reecan Blues. I say again: Why must we label people at all? Check one race? How about The Human Race.

Nigger-Reecan Blues by Willie Perdomo

NOTE: a link to the video of Willie Perdomo performing this selection is included at the end of this file. Multiple characters are portrayed.

Hey, Willie. What are you, man? Boricua *(a Puerto Rican, especially one living in the United States.)* ? Moreno? *(A Spanish term to refer to individual of dark skin tones)* Que?

I am.

No, silly. You know what I mean: What are you?

I am you. You are me. We the same. Can't you feel our veins drinking the

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same blood?

—But who said you was a Porta Reecan?

—Tú no eres Puerto Riqueño, brother.

—Maybe Indian like Gandhi Indian.

—I thought you was a Black man.

—Is one of your parents white?

—You sure you ain't a mix of something like

—Portuguese and Chinese?

—Naaaahhhh…You ain't no Porta Reecan.

—I keep telling you: The boy is a Black man with an accent.

If you look closely you will see that your spirits are standing right next to
our songs. Yo soy Boricua! You soy Africano! I ain't lyin'. Pero mi pelo es
kinky y kurly y mi skin no es negra pero it can pass…

—Hey, yo. I don't care what you say—you Black.

I ain't Black! Everytime I go downtown *la madam blankeeta de madeeson*
avenue sees that I'm standing right next to her and she holds her purse just
a bit tighter. I can't even catch a taxi late at night and the newspapers say
that if I'm not in front of a gun, chances are that I'll be behind one. I won-
der why…

—Cuz you Black, nigger.

I ain't Black, man. I had a conversation with my professor. Went like this:

—Where are you from, Willie?

—I'm from Harlem.

—Ohh! Are you Black?

—No, but—

—Do you play much basketball?

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Te lo estoy diciendo, brother. Ese hombre es un
moreno!
Míralo!
Mira yo no soy moreno! I just come out of Jerry's Den
and the
coconut
spray off my new shape-up sails around the corner, up to
the Harlem
River and off to New Jersey. I'm lookin' slim and I'm
lookin' trim
and when my homeboy Davi saw me, he said: "*Coño, Papo.*
Te
parece como
un moreno, brother. Word up, bro. You look like a stone
black
kid."

—I told you—you was Black.

Damn! I ain't even Black and here I am sufferin' from
the young

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Black man's plight/the old white man's burden/and I ain't
even
Black, man/a Black man/I am not/Boricua I am/ain't
never really
was/Black/like me…

—Leave that boy alone. He got the Nigger-Reecan Blues

I'm a Spic!
I'm a Nigger!
Spic! Spic! No different than a Nigger!
Neglected, rejected, oppressed, and depressed

From banana boats to tenements
Street gangs to regiments…
Spic! Spic! I ain't nooooo different than a Nigger.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Willie Perdomo
Book: Where a Nickel Costs a Dime
ISBN: 9780393313833
Publisher: W.W. Norton and Company
Date (Month/Year): March 1996

Watch Willie Perdomo preform this poem at
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Mvo0g3dHAHw

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